

Meeting 4: Research Design Returned

Discussing your C3 drafts and next steps
Bachelor Project 2025–2026

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Wednesday 13 May 2026
Mandeville T3-09, 12:00–14:45

Today's Agenda

1. Method walkthroughs on the course site
2. Where you are this week
3. What A4 was meant to settle
4. Walking through each project
5. Privacy checklists
6. What A5 looks like

Method walkthroughs on the course site

Three short walkthroughs are now on the course page on my personal site, under **Methods walkthroughs** (same password).

- OLS regression in R
- Panel data with fixed effects in R
- NLP pipeline in Python

Each one runs end to end on simulated data themed around digital governance, so you can adapt the code to your own design. These are the basics and the baseline expectation for a bachelor's thesis. Feel free to add complexity for the relevant estimation method, as long as you understand what you are doing. Optional, not required. Read whichever is closest to the method you are weighing for A4.

Where you are this week

Working across the group

- Conceptual models with directions of effect
- Operationalisation moving from concepts to indicators
- Specific datasets named (V-Dem DSP, AidData, OVD-Info, Wayback, Lighthouse)
- Hypotheses committing to a direction

Still to land for A5

- For most of you, data construction has not started yet
- Operationalisation tables where the design has several indicators
- C3 in continuous prose where outline-style notes remain
- Word count on the cover for every submission

What A4 was meant to settle

By A4, every project should have established:

1. A **named source** for each variable (which dataset, which corpus, which platform)
2. A **measurement rule** for each concept (which V-Dem indicator, which clause category, which legal article)
3. A **time window** (start year, end year, and any lag)
4. A **sample frame** (which countries, which platforms, which municipalities, which cases)
5. An **ethics line** that names the actual risk, not a generic disclaimer

Where any of these is still open in your draft, that is the work to close before A5.

How the next 2h45 will run

Two groups of four, about 20 minutes per person, with a 5-minute break between groups:

1. I read your equation back to you.
2. Your cross-feedback partner opens with one execution question.
3. We open it to the room.
4. You leave with one commitment for A5 (Tuesday 19 May, 11:00).

$$\text{Outcome} = \text{effect} \times \text{the thing you think drives it} + (\text{controls})$$

Every term in the equation should now have a dataset and a coding rule.

Group A: 12:00–13:20

Text-as-data and cross-national designs

Cross-feedback pairs: Kate ↔ Lea Kseniya ↔ Daniel

Kate Domnikoff: regulatory complexity (GDPR × DMA)

Where you are: C2 now has the Robb taxonomy and the responsive-regulation pyramid in place. C3 was not part of this submission.

$$\text{Compliance outcome} = \text{effect} \times \text{Complexity index} + (\text{firm size, sector})$$

Discuss with Lea, then with the room:

- **Halstead on legal text:** what counts as an operator vs an operand when the “code” is GDPR and DMA articles? One paragraph in C3.
- **Y in one phrase:** enforcement decisions against the seven gatekeepers since 2023, with fine value and decision count, or policy edits? Settle on one before A5.
- **C3 sketch for A5:** corpus, complexity measure, outcome variable, time window.

Lea Géciová: protective vs oppressive digital sovereignty

Where you are: Two composite indices built (3 V-Dem items defensive, 4 offensive), panel 2011–2023, OECD-38, Maerz (2025) as the convergent-validity anchor.

$$\text{Internet freedom} = \beta_1 \times \text{Defensive DS} + \beta_2 \times \text{Offensive DS} + \text{moderation by libdem}$$

Hypothesis: $\beta_1 < 0$ (protective $\rightarrow$ freer), $\beta_2 > 0$ (oppressive $\rightarrow$ less free).

Discuss with Kate, then with the room:

- **Cybersecurity capacity on the defensive side:** dual-use concern. One sentence in C2 on why it belongs there.
- **Rename:** “protective” and “oppressive” read more clearly than defensive and offensive.
- **Operationalisation table** for A5: five composite items plus moderator plus two controls, all in one table.

Kseniya Sidorenko: digital mobilisation and sentencing severity

Where you are: Full C3 in 1,665 words; ordered logit with interaction; three robustness checks; ethics handled.

$$\text{Sentence severity (0-7)} = \beta_1 \times \text{Visibility} + \beta_2 \times \text{Post-Feb 2022} + \beta_3 \times \text{Visibility} \times \text{Post-Feb 2022} + \text{controls}$$

The empirical question is whether $\beta_3 \neq 0$.

Discuss with Daniel, then with the room:

- **Pre-trial detention** is a plausible confound on the mobilisation coefficient. Can you extract a detention flag from OVD-Info case text?
- **OLS robustness** on sentence length within the imprisoned subsample: check for right-skew, log-transform if so.
- **Typo** “2018–1025” in the validity section.

Daniel Ugarte: digitally restrictive legislation and backsliding (HU)

Where you are: H2 stated, conceptual model has the framing mechanism, methodology has dictionary-based content analysis plus process tracing.

$$\mathbf{H1:} \text{ V-Dem}_t = \beta \times \text{Restrictive laws}_{t-k}$$

$$\mathbf{H2:} \text{ Discretion score of law} = \beta \times \text{Year passed}$$

Discuss with Kseniya, then with the room:

- **Fill the dictionary:** four categories, five Hungarian terms each, tied to Varol / Earl / Roberts / Schumann. Main piece of work for A5.
- **Coding rule:** binary or cumulative score. Defend the choice in one paragraph before coding starts.
- **Hungarian originals** for dictionary application; DeepL only for the qualitative process-tracing read.

Group B: 13:25–14:45

Case, applied, and mixed designs

Cross-feedback pairs: Anand ↔ Vince Francis ↔ Louiza

Anand Dev Esponda: ownership concentration and Gen Z trust (NL)

Where you are: Scope is now Gen Z in the Netherlands. C2 reorganised around three mechanisms. C3 flagged as still in progress.

$$\text{Political trust (NL Gen Z)} = \text{effect} \times \text{Exposure to concentrated platforms} + (\text{controls})$$

Discuss with Vince, then with the room:

- **Y has to come from a NL source:** European Social Survey trust items, Eurobarometer, or your own survey. Settle which before A5.
- **Hypothesis** still references “US politics” while the population is Dutch Gen Z. Align hypothesis and population.
- If running your own survey: **informed consent form** alongside the privacy checklist. Pilot with 5 before the full 80.

Vince Kromberg: ToS clauses and regulatory shocks

Where you are: Section 2.4 written, two hypotheses, three-stage analytical procedure (segmentation, classification, rubric-based scoring), three platforms across three measurement years.

ToS clause direction (+1 / 0 / -1) measured at 2017, 2019, 2024 across Upwork, Fiverr, AMT, on fee clauses and termination clauses

Discuss with Anand, then with the room:

- **Wayback confirmation:** which exact snapshots exist for all three platforms in all three years? Two sentences or a footnote with URLs in C3.
- **Lock the rubric:** platform-favourable and worker-favourable marker lists as a table, sourced to Weil, Rosenblat & Stark, Cohen.
- **Discrepancy threshold** on the 10% manual check: what % disagreement triggers a keyword revision?

Francis van Luyn: Digital Silk Road and ASEAN sovereignty

Where you are: Framework in place: lock-in via Bokolo, infrastructuring via Musiani, AidData on X, V-Dem DSP on Y. C3 has several open questions to close.

$$\text{Digital sovereignty (DSP-based index)}_t = \text{effect} \times \text{Chinese-built infrastructure (AidData)}_{t-5}$$

Country-year panel, ASEAN-10, 2013–2023 with a five-year build-out lag.

Discuss with Louiza, then with the room:

- **Unit of analysis** is country-year, not project. AidData collapses to country-year by ICT, telecom, and data-centre sector flows.
- **Y as a DSP-based index:** pick 3–4 indicators (filtering capacity, monitoring, regulation approach) and build one composite.
- **Lag of 5 years** is defensible as a build-out window. Justify in one sentence in C3.

Louiza Reysen: digital accessibility of German municipal websites

Where you are: C2 narrower (digital divide and institutional isomorphism). Path dependency added as a theoretical mechanism. C3 is currently in outline form.

$$\text{Accessibility score (Lighthouse)} = \beta_1 \times \text{Size} + \beta_2 \times \text{Website creation date} + \beta_3 \times \text{Political control}$$

Discuss with Francis, then with the room:

- **Which Lighthouse score?** Performance, Accessibility, Best Practices, SEO are four separate 0–100 scores. Name one.
- **Sampling procedure** in prose: which random number generator, which list of ~11,000 municipalities, exclusion criteria?
- **Path dependency from Wayback:** does the Wayback Machine return reliable “first online” dates for a typical municipality, or only current-CMS dates?

Privacy checklists

All eight checklists are now signed and on file. Thank you.

- For projects with primary data from human participants, the informed consent form is required before any data is collected.
- For secondary-data projects, the checklist covers your use of public datasets and any AI tooling in your pipeline.
- If anything in your design changes between now and A6 (different population, different instrument, AI tool added), please flag it so we can reassess.

What A5 looks like (Tuesday 19 May, 11:00 on Canvas)

A5 is the progress check. What I am looking for is evidence that data construction has actually started, not just been planned. For each project that means something specific:

Panel designs	Merged country-year file built; descriptives on the key indices
Text-as-data	Corpus retrieved, segmented, first-pass coded on at least one document
Case data	Matched analytical dataset built; first model run
Web-scraping	Sample drawn, scraping tool tested on a small subset
Survey	Instrument drafted and piloted, or secondary survey dataset confirmed
C3 catch-up	A complete C3 in continuous prose

Meeting 5: Thursday 21 May, regular slot.

Discussion

Before you leave, around the room:

1. One sentence: what does your A5 deliverable look like on screen next Tuesday?
2. One thing that could realistically go wrong, and your plan B.
3. One question for the room that you do not yet have an answer to.

90 seconds each.

Key References

Operationalisation of contested concepts (digital governance):

- Mechkova, V., Pemstein, D., Seim, B. & Wilson, S.L. (2025). Measuring online political activity: introducing the DSP dataset. *Journal of Information Technology & Politics*, 22(3), 279–295.
- Maerz, S.F. (2025). How practices of digital authoritarianism harm democracy. *Democratization*, 33(1), 1–28.
- Schumann, M.P. (2026). Legalizing control: the rise of restrictive internet regulation in sub-Saharan Africa. *Democratization*, 33(1), 137–162.

Design and replication:

- King, G., Keohane, R.O. & Verba, S. (1994). *Designing Social Inquiry*. Princeton UP.
- Bryman, A. (2016). *Social Research Methods*, Ch. 7. Oxford UP.

Ethics:

- KNAW (2024). *Evaluation Committee Recommendations on Research Integrity*.

Questions?

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